

Impact of the Missouri Compromise on Enslaved African Americans

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During the events of the Missouri Compromise, Dred Scott, an enslaved man who was impacted by the legislative act sought freedom for himself and his family. He lived in both the free and slave territories and his fight for liberation showed how the legal framework around the Missouri Compromise did not favor the African Americans. Dred Scott, like countless others, was born into slavery and sold as property to Dr. John Emerson, a military surgeon. Scott's life was a painful reminder of how the Missouri Compromise failed enslaved people. Even after living in free territories like Illinois and the Wisconsin Territory where slavery was banned, he was forced back into enslavement in Missouri. His fight for freedom would expose the harsh realities of laws that prioritized politics over human lives. His legal fight went up all the way to the Supreme Court case *Dred Scott v. Sandford*,¹ which declared that African Americans, whether free or enslaved, could not be considered citizens of the United States and had no right to sue in federal court.² This research then analyzed the lived experience of enslaved African Americans during the era of the Missouri Compromise from 1820 to 1854, focusing on how this legislative act affected their daily lives and struggles for freedom. By examining the experiences of men, women, and children, including the harsh realities of their living conditions and housing during enslavement, it becomes evident that the Compromise effectively solidified the institution of slavery in the new territories, reinforcing systemic oppression that left enslaved Africans with no avenue for liberation.³

¹ The clerk misspelled Sanford's name during the court case title resulting it to be *Dred Scott v. Sandford* instead of "Dred Scott v. Sanford" (without the d).

² Maltz, Earl M., *Dred Scott and the Politics of Slavery*. (Lawrence: University Press of Kansas, 2007), 61. <https://dx.doi.org/10.1353/book.123657>.

³ Brekke, Jerry, and Fulton, Richard, *Understanding Missouri's Constitutional Government*. (Columbia: University of Missouri Press, 2010), 145. <https://muse.jhu.edu/book/22331>.

For years, the impact of slavery on American history has left a lasting imprint on the social and political landscape, shaping debates and policies that were repeated through generations. To understand how slavery was seen in the United States, particularly in the lives of African Americans, this research uses the Missouri Compromise as a primary example and how the enslaved lives were impacted. As Matthew Hall states, The Missouri Compromise of 1820 was a decision based on whim that was put together by Congress to resolve the issue of slavery that was increasingly expanding in the West.⁴ The compromise, which created a geographical line extending the southern border of Missouri westward to divide slave and free territory, was widely viewed as a victory for the South.⁵ They were Missouri, Kentucky, Virginia, North Carolina, Tennessee, Georgia, Mississippi, Alabama, Louisiana, Arkansas and Florida territory. However, the Missouri Compromise ultimately failed to address the fundamental issues related to slavery in the United States, instead serving as a temporary measure that merely postponed the inevitable confrontation with the conflict between slavery and American ideals. The Missouri Compromise drew a line across the country, not just on a map but in the lives of African Americans. For enslaved men, women, and children, it deepened their suffering, trapping them in a system that dehumanized and denied them the most basic rights. This paper explores the lived experiences of those impacted, focusing on their daily struggles and the resilience they displayed in the face of immense hardship. Even though the Compromise Act was viewed as a practical solution to resolve the expansion of slavery and maintain a balance between the free and slave states, it still drew attention to the lack of regard for the people that it subjugated. As Robert

⁴ Hall, Matthew W., *Dividing the Union: Jesse Burgess Thomas and the Making of the Missouri Compromise*. (Carbondale: Southern Illinois University Press, 2015), 1. <https://muse.jhu.edu/book/43239>.

⁵ Hall, Matthew W., *Dividing the Union*, 1.

Forbes' *Missouri Compromise and Its Aftermath* reveals, the Compromise effectively solidified the institution of slavery further enhancing the dehumanization of African Americans.⁶

The Black Code in the Missouri Territory serves as a crucial example of this issue that was made after the United States acquisition of the Louisiana Territory in 1803. It reflected the systemic control imposed on African Americans through legislative measures.⁷ These laws treated enslaved people as no different from other forms of personal property and imposed severe restrictions controlling their behavior. Slaves were not allowed to leave their master's property without their permission, they couldn't own guns or any other form of weapons, and if they did, they were sometimes killed as an act of rebellion or conspiracy.⁸ They also could not gather together in what was defined as unlawful assemblies. Anyone who was found violating these rules faced severe punishment, including public whippings.⁹ The Black Code was very restrictive and dehumanizing. This code illustrates how legislative frameworks reinforced the broader oppression that characterized the Missouri Compromise era. The enactment of such laws perpetuated the perception of African Americans as property, maintaining a structure where their rights and humanity were systematically denied. By imposing strict controls and limiting interactions with a free society, the laws aimed to reduce the risk of rebellion or escape, effectively entrenching the institution of slavery further.¹⁰ These measures resonate with the

⁶ Forbes, Robert P., *Missouri Compromise and Its Aftermath: Slavery and the Meaning of America*. (Chapel Hill: University of North Carolina Press. 2007), 2. <https://heinonline-org.lscsproxy.lonestar.edu/HOL/Page?handle=hein.slavery/uncaaea0001&id=1&collection=slavery&index=#>.

⁷ Missouri Secretary of State, "Missouri's Early Slave Laws: A History in Documents." Missouri Digital Heritage. <https://www.sos.mo.gov/archives/education/aahi/earlyslavelaws/slavelaws>.

⁸ Greene, Lorenzo J. et. al., *Missouri's Black Heritage*. (Columbia and London: University of Missouri Press, 1993) 38. <https://archive.org/details/missourisblackhe00gree/page/n4/mode/1up?view=theater>.

⁹ Missouri Secretary of State, "Missouri's Early Slave Laws: A History in Documents." Missouri Digital Heritage. <https://www.sos.mo.gov/archives/education/aahi/earlyslavelaws/slavelaws>.

¹⁰ Missouri Secretary of State, "Missouri's Early Slave Laws: A History in Documents"

analysis of how the Missouri Compromise, though aimed at balancing power between free and slave states, upheld and adapted systems of control to ensure that enslavement remained deeply embedded in society. The Black Code exemplifies how legal mechanisms were used to reinforce a racial hierarchy, demonstrating that even when territorial expansions and legislative compromises were made, they continued to sustain and evolve the system of subjugation.

The events leading up to the Missouri Compromise were marked by intense political debates and a rapidly changing American landscape. The timeline of the Missouri Compromise highlights the pivotal moments that led to the passage of the Compromise and the events that followed as tensions over slavery intensified. In early 1819, Missouri's request for statehood sparked intense debates in Congress, revealing the deep-seated divisions between Northern and Southern states over the expansion of slavery. Congressman James Tallmadge, Jr. introduced the Tallmadge Amendment on February 13, 1819, aiming to restrict slavery in Missouri and gradually emancipate enslaved individuals when they turned 25 years of age.¹¹ The amendment passed in the House but was struck down in the Senate, showing how the controversial debates that would shape the Compromise would be made. By March 1820, after months of fierce debate, the Missouri Compromise was enacted, drawing a line at 36°30' latitude. This division permitted slavery in Missouri but prohibited it in the remaining territories of the Louisiana Purchase north of the line. The Compromise aimed to maintain a fragile balance of power between free and slave states, with Maine entering as a free state to offset Missouri's admission as a slave state.¹² Despite this temporary solution, the Compromise merely delayed the inevitable feud between the North and South that would eventually lead to the Civil War between the

¹¹ Miller, Marion M., "The Missouri Compromise", in *Great Debates in American History*. (New York: Current Literature Publishing Company, 1915), 43. <https://heinonline-org.lscsproxy.lonestar.edu/HOL/Page?handle=hein.congrec/gredehi0004&id=52&collection=slavery&index=>.

¹² Miller, Marion M., "The Missouri Compromise", in *Great Debates in American History*, 261.

Unions and the Confederates. Rochelle Riley's assertion that "enslavement did not end, but just 'changed addresses'" resonates deeply with the themes explored in this research, as it captures the essence of the Missouri Compromise's impact. Although the Compromise was intended to create a balance between free and slave states, it ultimately represented a shift in the manifestation of oppression rather than its eradication.¹³ The legislation reinforced systemic control over African Americans, showing how, despite geographic and legislative distinctions between free and slave states, the reality of enslavement persisted in various forms.

It is important to understand that the Missouri Compromise's significance lies not only in its immediate political impact but also in its profound and lasting consequences for the lives of enslaved African Americans. Understanding these effects is crucial because the Compromise perpetuated the brutal system of slavery and reinforced the notion that human lives could be legislated and divided along geographical lines.¹⁴ The Compromise symbolized the federal government's willingness to prioritize political stability over human rights, a decision that condemned countless African Americans to continued suffering and dehumanization. The lived experiences of those enslaved under the Missouri Compromise were faced with fear, anger, oppression, frustration, and depression. While the act may have been portrayed to be a "practical" solution, it ignored human dignity and justice.

In the lives of the African men, the Compromise impacted their daily lives which was designed by a system that denied them freedom and dignity. Dred Scott, like many other enslaved African men highlights the struggles that they faced. While he was being moved between free and slave states, he had to endure years of forced labor.¹⁵ His labor involved

¹³ Harper, Misti Nicole, "The Burden: African Americans and the Enduring Impact of Slavery." *Arkansas Review: A Journal of Delta Studies* 49, no. 3 (2018): 228-30.
<https://research-ebsco-com.lscsproxy.lonestar.edu/linkprocessor/plink?id=531f6b98-a614-3982-9ec7-f657dd37cd62>.

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Brekke, Jerry, and Fulton, Richard, *Understanding Missouri's Constitutional Government*. 145

¹⁵ Maltz, Earl M., *Dred Scott and the Politics of Slavery*. 60.

picking cotton, taking care of horses, and other backbreaking tasks that were both physically exhausting and mentally draining.¹⁶ For enslaved African men like Scott, the threat of punishment constantly happened. Enslaved men were not only subjected to severe physical labor but were manipulated to form attachments with enslaved women to discourage escape or rebellion.¹⁷

The Missouri Compromise shaped the daily realities of these men, who were predominantly forced to labor on large plantations. Most worked from sunrise to sunset, cultivating crops like tobacco, cotton, and wheat or tending to livestock such as pigs and cattle. For some slave men, like Richard Bruner and Gus Smith, the harsh demands of slavery began in childhood. Richard Bruner recalled working as a water boy in the fields before being deemed old enough for more rigorous tasks, while Gus Smith started laboring at just five years old, enduring long days with little rest.¹⁸ Earl Maltz notes that even minor transgression could result in severe beatings, a punishment often used to enforce obedience and instill fear. During Scott's stay at Fort Armstrong with his master, Dr. John Emerson, his duties were not detailed into account, but it was said that his master was never happy with how he worked.¹⁹ It is important to note that some treatment of slaves varied depending on their master's mood or attitude towards them.²⁰ The psychological toll was immense, as Scott, like many other men, lived under the constant fear of being sold from one master to another. Having been resold multiple times, Scott struggled with depression, fearing he would never meet his master's expectations. This fear, combined

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Lea, Vandervelde, *Redemption Songs: Suing for Freedom before Dred Scott*. (New York: Oxford University Press, 2014), 193. <https://archive.org/details/redemptionsongss0000vand>.

¹⁷ Lea, Vandervelde, *Redemption Songs: Suing for Freedom before Dred Scott*. 193.

¹⁸ Greene, Lorenzo J. et. al., *Missouri's Black Heritage*. 26.

¹⁹ Maltz, Earl M., *Dred Scott and the Politics of Slavery*, 61.

²⁰ Greene, Lorenzo J. et. al., *Missouri's Black Heritage*, 28.

with the grueling work, created an environment of sustained trauma and emotional distress. Dred Scott was continually transferred from one territory to another, which not only disrupted any sense of stability he might have hoped to achieve but also highlighted the uncertain existence endured by enslaved men.²¹ This constant movement between slave and free territories exemplifies the arbitrary and dehumanizing nature of the laws that governed the lives of African Americans. Despite residing in areas where slavery was technically illegal, Scott's status as a piece of property, rather than a human being with rights, dictated that he could be uprooted and moved by his enslaver's will.

The general experiences of enslaved African men across the South and territories like Missouri were similarly harrowing to what Dred Scott faced. Richard Bruner, Gus Smith, and many other enslaved men were often tasked with agricultural labor, such as planting and harvesting crops in large gardens, which required long hours in oppressive heat, with little nourishment or medical health care.²² And if they ever disobeyed, they were severely beaten to the point that the brutal nature of their treatment, as in most cases of extreme violence was normalized and went unpunished in the legal aspect. Other methods of punishment such as being hung up by their thumbs were used as a means of control and intimidation. Some slaves were punished in front of other slaves as a lesson to other slaves if they were to also be disobedient.²³ Despite the harsh realities, some slaves were given only Sunday afternoons off. During this brief time off, enslaved men would take on odd jobs or perform in parades, singing songs or playing marbles.²⁴ It was the only time they were ever truly happy because it was something they enjoyed

²¹ Maltz, Earl M, *Dred Scott and the Politics of Slavery*, 63.

²² Forbes, Robert P., *Missouri Compromise and Its Aftermath: Slavery and the Meaning of America*, 38.

²³ Greene, Lorenzo J. et. al., 29-31.

²⁴ Greene, Lorenzo J. et. al., 33.

doing and did of their own free will and not from their masters. However, such jobs were typically underpaid, and these men were overwhelmingly exploited for their labor. The Missouri Compromise did little to mitigate these conditions, as the legislation mainly reinforced the systemic exploitation of African labor. Men who worked in fields or on construction projects faced relentless work schedules that left them physically depleted and vulnerable to illness or injury, with no rights or avenues for liberation.

When Dred Scott was about thirty-three years old, He moved again with his master, John Emerson, to Fort Snelling in Illinois where his master was posted for, as a medical doctor in the military field. Slavery was also illegal in this territory, but this territory was where he found another female slave, Harriet Robinson. She was about seventeen years old when they met and he would eventually marry her even though it was illegal for slaves to officially have a wedding.²⁵ Since two slaves from two different masters couldn't marry, she was then sold to Dr John Emerson who then allowed their marriage.²⁶ The Missouri Compromise's influence on the lives of enslaved African American women was also profound, shaping their experiences in uniquely challenging ways. Women like Harriet Scott, Celia, Isabelle Henderson, Harriet Casey, and Emma Knight bore the dual burden of laboring both in the fields and in domestic roles, all while facing the constant threat of physical and sexual violence.²⁷ Celia, who became enslaved at 14, was repeatedly raped by her master, Robert Newman, for years. Her master viewed her as just a property and felt entitled to her. The psychological devastation she endured led to a breaking point when, after refusing to sleep with him, she killed him in self-defense.²⁸ She

²⁵ Lea, Vandervelde. *Redemption Songs: Suing for Freedom before Dred Scott*, 205.

²⁶ Miller, Marion M, "The Missouri Compromise", in *Great Debates in American History*, 377.

²⁷ Lea, Vandervelde, *Redemption Songs: Suing for Freedom before Dred Scott*, 131.

²⁸ McLaurin, Melton A., *Celia, a Slave*. (Athens: University of Georgia Press, 2008), 30. Project MUSE, <https://dx.doi.org/10.1353/book11471>.

couldn't come to terms with her rape incident because of the multiple sexual encounters by Robert Newman. Because of that, it had a physical strain on her due to the multiple sexual exploitation.²⁹ Isabelle Henderson, a slave in Saline County, worked as a domestic laborer, sewing clothes and nursing her mistress's children. Similarly, Emma Knight and her three sisters were responsible for physically demanding labor, such as cutting weeds, pulling them from gardens, feeding livestock, and hoeing. Margaret Davis, another enslaved woman, began working at the young age of 10 as a nursemaid, standing on a chair to wash her master's family's clothes.³⁰ These women, though tasked with grueling labor, were often subjected to sexual assault by their masters, a harsh reality that enslaved women endured even when they resisted.

Whenever women were in slave auctions, the person hosting the auction would yell to people looking to buy women slaves about whether they could wash, cook, or clean. Many women played a crucial role in challenging the conditions imposed by slavery, often fighting not only for their own freedom but also for the protection of their children.³¹ Their maternal instinct drove them to ensure their children were free from fear and separation. For many women fighting for freedom, the absence of information about fathers in legal cases was common due to their irrelevance or because the fathers could be anyone, including slave masters or other slaves. Harriet Robinson's story provides a compelling example of the hardships that enslaved women endured and the resilience they displayed in the face of systemic oppression. Harriet Robinson exemplified the multiple challenges faced by enslaved women. Like many enslaved women, Harriet's daily life involved relentless physical labor that stretched from agricultural work to domestic responsibilities within her enslaver's household. This work was exhausting and

²⁹ McLaurin, Melton A., *Celia, a Slave*, 23.

³⁰ Greene, Lorenzo J. et. al., 25.

³¹ Lea, Vandervelde, 195.

extended her day well beyond the grueling hours that men typically endured. The dual roles that Harriet performed illustrate how enslaved women were indispensable to the job of harvesting and gardening, contributing not only to economic productivity but also to the maintenance of the household, which was vital to the social structure of the slave-owning class.³² The laws reinforced by the Missouri Compromise did nothing to protect enslaved women; instead, these laws implicitly sanctioned the power that enslavers held over their bodies and lives. This reality meant that these women lived under the constant anxiety of abuse that could occur at any moment. The psychological and physical trauma inflicted by such violence had long-term consequences on enslaved women's health and well-being, influencing their ability to care for their children and sustain familial bonds.³³ This was part of a broader strategy by slaveholders to maintain control, ensuring that women remained submissive and that children born to them would inherit the status of enslavement, reinforcing the economic stability of the system.

The Missouri Compromise had far-reaching implications not only for men and women but also for the youngest and most vulnerable members of enslaved communities, children. The conditions created and sustained by the Compromise entrenched a system where children were viewed as assets and potential laborers rather than as human beings with inherent worth. The Missouri Compromise on children showed how the legislation's reinforcement of slavery affected the physical, emotional, and social lives of enslaved children. One of the most significant impacts of the Missouri Compromise on children was the lack of proper care at birth.³⁴ Doctors rarely assisted with deliveries, leaving mothers to endure childbirth without medical support. This neglect often had tragic consequences, such as the case of Dred and

³² Forbes, Robert P., 38.

³³ Maltz, Earl M., 63.

³⁴ Burke, Diane M., *On Slavery's Border: Missouri's Small Slaveholding Households, 1815-65*. (Athens: University of Georgia Press, 2010), 89. Project MUSE. <https://dx.doi.org/10.1353/book11482>.

Harriet's two baby boys who died due to inadequate care, as they were forced to work tirelessly for their enslavers with no time or resources to provide sufficient attention to their newborns. The health and survival of infants were a second priority of their parents, highlighting the devaluation of enslaved children's lives from the moment they were born. Children were often separated from their families as part of the economic strategies employed by slaveholders. Enslaved children were frequently sold to generate income for their masters, leading to the forced separation of families and deep emotional trauma.³⁵ Unlike the adult men and women, the value of children was not based on their well-being but on their potential to grow up and contribute to the labor force as a slave.³⁶ For example, Dred and Harriet Scott combined would have an estimated value of \$1,000 while their daughter alone, Eliza Scott, could fetch up to \$750. It showed how children were seen as investments by slaveholders.

Beyond economic value, enslaved children faced systemic barriers to education. Slaveowners feared that literacy would inspire rebellion, especially with the circulation of abolitionist literature and newspapers.³⁷ By 1847, laws had been enacted that criminalized teaching enslaved individuals to read, with severe penalties for anyone caught doing so, including fines and imprisonment. This denial of education ensured that enslaved children remained dependent on their oppressors and deprived them of the tools necessary to seek freedom.³⁸ Although enslaved men and women were also denied education, this deprivation was prevalent among children. This is because they were younger and eager to learn before their desire to learn was crushed by the harsh realities that they would then face. Children were also

³⁵ Lea, Vandervelde, 60.

³⁶ Lea, Vandervelde, 61.

³⁷ Greene, Lorenzo J. et. al., 38.

³⁸ Greene, Lorenzo J. et. al., 38.

pushed into roles of responsibility at a young age, often taking on parental duties when their parents were working in the fields or performing other laborious tasks.³⁹ This forced maturity robbed them of their childhood and placed them under immense pressure. Young children, particularly older siblings, were expected to care for their brothers and sisters, ensuring their safety and well-being despite lacking the resources or emotional support themselves. Just like in the case of when Harriet Scott had another baby girl after Eliza, who was about seven years old. Eliza had to take on the role of watching her little sister, Lizzie. This dynamic of taking on the role of a parent meant that even from an early age, children were mixed up in the realities of enslavement, experiencing the fear, loss, and hardship that defined their parents' lives. The trauma of being "snatched away" from their families was a constant threat to enslaved children.⁴⁰ The pervasive risk of separation instilled a sense of insecurity and fear that shaped their formative years. For Dred and Harriet Scott's children, growing up under the shadow of the Missouri Compromise meant living with the knowledge that their fate was dictated by a system that treated them as property, subject to the whims of their enslaver. The Missouri Compromise not only reinforced the physical exploitation of enslaved children but also contributed to their emotional and psychological distress. By maintaining the structure of slavery, it created an environment where children could not rely on the security and care that family life should provide.

The harsh living conditions endured by enslaved individuals compounded the struggles faced by men, women, and children, reinforcing the systemic oppression present in every aspect of their lives. The living conditions of enslaved individuals were as dehumanizing as the labor they endured. Harriet Casey recalled that in her county, 987 slaves were crammed into just 19

³⁹ Lea, Vandervelde, 61.

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Lea, Vandervelde, 64.

cabins. Her family of 11 lived in a single-room space, often sharing it with rats and enduring extreme heat in summer and freezing temperatures in winter.⁴¹ Cabins were often crudely constructed, made of logs sealed with mud, and lacked proper windows or floors. The overcrowded cabins not only deprived enslaved families of privacy but also exposed them to unsanitary conditions, which frequently led to illness and further reduced their already limited quality of life. Such conditions left men physically depleted after long days of labor, women struggling to maintain domestic life, and children vulnerable to exposure and illness. The lack of proper shelter reinforced the message that enslaved individuals were not seen as people deserving of care but as property to be maintained only enough to ensure continued productivity. Most enslaved individuals slept on bare floors, as mattresses were rarely provided.⁴² For women like Harriet Casey, who not only labored in the fields but also bore the responsibility of raising children, these living conditions added another layer of hardship. The psychological toll of trying to create a home in such dehumanizing circumstances was immense, particularly for mothers who hoped to shield their children from the worst realities of enslavement. Children, who were already subjected to long hours of labor and denied education, faced additional challenges in such overcrowded and unsanitary environments. The poor living conditions provided no relief or comfort from their grueling labor, further exemplifying the complete disregard for their humanity and wellbeing. Due to this Dred was very persistent in freeing his family because he wanted his children to live their remaining years of life without the bondage of being owned by a slaveholder. Dred and his wife, Harriet found hope in winning their legal case when another enslaved woman, Rachel won her freedom in court by suing her owner for the same reasons Dred was going to sue John Sanford, which was enslavement in free territories.

⁴¹ Greene, Lorenzo J. et. al., 31.

⁴² Greene, Lorenzo J. et. al., 32.

With court cases, other enslaved African women like Rachel endured relentless labor and the challenges of seeking freedom through legal means as part of their daily lives.⁴³ Her story serves as a testament to the resilience and determination shown by enslaved African American women who sought legal avenues to challenge their conditions. She sued William Walker, who was her master at the time, to gain her freedom. She used the freedom by residence law to fight for her rights. Her previous owner was a United States Army officer, T. B.W. Stockton, who had taken her to Prairie du Chien in the Michigan Territory, an area governed by the Northwest Ordinance, which prohibited slavery.⁴⁴ Despite Stockton's military orders placing him in free territory, Rachel was sold to Walker. Initially, the St. Louis Circuit Court ruled against her, stating that Stockton had no choice in his residency. However, her case did not end there. In 1836, Rachel's case reached Missouri Supreme Court Justice Mathias McGirk, who applied a strict interpretation of the 1824 statute and ultimately granted her liberty.⁴⁵ This victory was significant because it demonstrated that despite the limitations of the Missouri Compromise and the prevailing pro-slavery legal environment, some legal battles could be won.

The Missouri Compromise's impact on enslaved African Americans was not only seen in the suffering it perpetuated but also in the remarkable resilience shown by those who fought against their conditions. The story of Dred Scott is one of the most significant examples of this resilience. Scott's legal battle began in the Missouri State Court, where he initially achieved a favorable verdict for freedom. However, this decision was later overturned by the Missouri

⁴³ *Rachel v. William Walker* Court Case document, (St. Louis: Washington University, 2016). <http://repository.wustl.edu/concern/texts/t722h9873>. This document has all the accounts and processes of Rachel's court case with William Walker.

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Siddali, Silvana R., ed., *Missouri's War: The Civil War in Documents*. (Athens: Ohio University Press, 2009), 41. ProQuest eBook Central, <https://ebookcentral-proquest-com.lscsproxy.lonestar.edu/lib/lonestar-ebooks/detail.action?docID=1773370>.

⁴⁵ Siddali, Silvana R., ed., *Missouri's War: The Civil War in Documents*. 41.

Supreme Court, illustrating the relentless obstacles Scott faced and his determination to continue fighting for his family. The inclusion of his wife, Harriet, and their daughters in the suit highlights the depth of Scott's resolve, as he pursued freedom not just for himself but for the protection and future of his loved ones.⁴⁶ The peak of Scott's journey in the Supreme Court case underscored the systemic barriers faced by African Americans. Chief Justice Roger B. Taney's majority opinion cruelly stated that, "They had for more than a century been regarded as beings of an inferior order, and altogether unfit to associate with white race... and so far inferior, they had no rights which the white man was bound to respect."⁴⁷ Exemplifying the deep-rooted racial ideologies that shaped U.S. law and society. This declaration reflected centuries of discriminatory beliefs used to justify slavery and deny African Americans basic rights. Slaveholders argued that they were doing the blacks a favor by enslaving them and it was for the benefit of the economy that they had slaves. Senator James Green of Lewis County in 1849 wrote that slaves were "happy inferiors" but obviously this description of slaves was not approved by current scholars but rather a stereotype created by slaveholders to respond to the attacks of the abolitionists of slavery.⁴⁸

Legally, it stripped African Americans, whether enslaved or free of citizenship and any standing in court, solidifying their exclusion from the protections of the Constitution. Taney's ruling reinforced white supremacy, empowering pro-slavery sentiment and normalizing racial hierarchies. It contradicted the principles of the Declaration of Independence and exposed the hypocrisy within American democracy, which claimed to uphold equality while perpetuating

⁴⁶ Howard, Benjamin C., *Report of the decision of the Supreme Court of the United States, and the opinions of the Judges Thereof, in the case of Dred Scott Versus John F. A. Sandford*. Library of Congress, (Washington: Cornelius Wendell, Printer), 5. 1857.

⁴⁷ Howard, Benjamin C., *Report of the decision of the Supreme Court of the United States*, 14.

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Greene, Lorenzo J. et. al., 28.

oppression. Ironically, this ruling intensified abolitionist efforts and highlighted the unsustainable divisions between free and slave states, fueling the national conflict that would eventually lead to the Civil War. Dred Scott's actions set a precedent and provided hope to the enslaved population. His case, although ultimately unsuccessful, underscored the potential for legal challenges and demonstrated the courage required to confront systemic oppression. The pursuit of freedom through legal avenues reflected a larger narrative of resistance that resonated with enslaved and free African Americans alike.

The Missouri Compromise, while intended as a political solution to balance power between free and slave states, ultimately failed to address the fundamental injustices of slavery and had profound and lasting consequences for the lives of enslaved African Americans. This paper has argued that the Compromise, rather than mitigating the horrors of slavery, instead served to solidify and adapt systems of control that ensured the continuation of this brutal institution. The Compromise drew a stark line across the nation, not only geographically but also symbolically, highlighting the federal government's willingness to prioritize political stability over human rights. This decision condemned countless individuals to continued suffering and dehumanization, as the Compromise effectively legalized and legitimized the ownership of human beings in certain territories. Examining the experiences of enslaved individuals like Dred Scott, his family, Richard Bruner, Gus Smith, Celia, Isabelle Henderson, Emma Knight, Margaret Davis, Rachel, and Harriet Casey reveals the deep-seated impact of the Missouri Compromise on men, women, and children. They all faced a constant threat of punishment and were subjected to grueling labor that left them physically and emotionally drained. The fear of being sold and separated from loved ones added another layer of trauma to their already precarious existence. For enslaved women, the Compromise reinforced their vulnerability to

sexual exploitation and violence, as they navigated the dual burdens of labor and motherhood under a system that offered them no protection. Their stories exemplified the resilience and strength displayed by enslaved women as they fought for their freedom and the well-being of their children. The Compromise's impact on children was particularly devastating, as it entrenched a system where they were seen as assets and potential laborers rather than as individuals deserving of care and compassion. The lack of proper healthcare at birth, denial of education, threat of family separation, and the forced assumption of adult responsibilities robbed enslaved children of their childhoods and exposed them to the harsh realities of slavery from a young age.

The Missouri Compromise also spurred resistance among enslaved African Americans, as individuals like Dred Scott and Rachel fought for their freedom through legal means. Rachel's successful lawsuit against her enslaver, William Walker, demonstrated that even within the constraints of a pro-slavery legal environment, legal victories were possible. Scott's journey through the court system, reaching up to the landmark Supreme Court case *Dred Scott v. Sandford*, serves as a powerful testament to the determination of enslaved people to challenge the system that oppressed them. While the Supreme Court's decision denied Scott and his family their freedom and stripped all African Americans of citizenship rights, it ironically served to stir up the abolitionist movement and expose the deep hypocrisy at the heart of American democracy. The Missouri Compromise stands as a clear reminder of the enduring legacy of slavery in American history. It highlights the complex ways in which legal frameworks and political compromises could be used to perpetuate injustice and deny basic human rights. While the Compromise ultimately failed to prevent the national conflict over slavery, it provided crucial

insights into the lives and experiences of enslaved African Americans, revealing their resilience, strength, and unwavering pursuit of freedom.

Future research could expand on this analysis by exploring the experiences of enslaved individuals fighting for their freedom in other territories beyond Missouri. Comparing and contrasting legal strategies, forms of resistance, and the impact of different state laws on the lives of enslaved people across the nation. It could offer a more nuanced understanding of the diverse experiences of enslaved populations and the broader fight for emancipation. Examining how enslaved individuals in different regions navigated the complexities of the legal system, formed networks of support, and challenged the institution of slavery would benefit our understanding of this crucial period in American history and its enduring relevance to modern discussions of race, justice, and equality.

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